CHAPTER 7

MEMORY, LANGUAGE AND FEEDBACK: KEYS TO SUCCESSFUL LEADERSHIP DEVELOPMENT

Summary

Although 360-degree reviews are widely used for leadership development, different evaluators may provide different, or even conflicting, feedback which makes it challenging to summarize the results. The different types of items used in 360-degree instruments contributes to this problem. We contend that understanding the distinction between concrete and abstract language, coupled with the intended purpose of the ratings, is the key for improving the quality of 360-degree reviews.

Chapter Outline

The 360- Degree Reviews and Memory

Downside of 360- Degree Reviews and How to Fix It

Why Words Matter

Improving 360- Feedback

Conclusion

Learning Outcomes

By the end of the chapter, readers should:

1. Understand that 360-degree questions based on behaviors are less ambiguous, reduce variation in the interpretation across evaluators, and are more useful for developmental feedback.

2. Be aware of the difference between episodic and semantic memory and the impact of concrete and abstract language on the type of memory used in completing the 360-degree feedback review.

3. Be aware of the potential for AI and Natural Language Processing models.

4. Be able to demonstrate an understanding of the Predictive Congruence Principle by aligning the types of items with the intended purpose and goals of the 360-degree feedback.

Personal Development Activities

Ask students to find a free 360-questionnaire and identify the items as concrete or abstract, perhaps providing instructions. Here is one free website https://hr-survey.com/360_Survey_Example_1.htm

- In a group, select a section on the questionnaire to classify items as abstract or concrete based on the definitions in the chapter. How many were abstract or concrete? Both?
- How might those items impact the quality of feedback received? To what extent do those items give a person information about what to do, stop doing, etc.?
- Given the results of your analysis, how well do these items align with the stated purpose and goals of the 360- degree feedback?

Links to Other Chapters

Chapter 8 also discusses memory processes in the context of identity.

Key Reading

Behr, J. (November, 22, 2019). Getting the most out of 360-degree reviews. Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/2019/11/getting-the-most-out-of-360-degree-reviews

Zenger, J. (2016, March 10). How effective are your 360-degree feedback assessments? Forbes. https://www.forbes.com/sites/jackzenger/2016/03/10/how-effective-are-your-360-degree-feedback-assessments/?sh=5dc54119a690

Zenger J. & Folkman, J. (December, 23, 2020). What makes a 360-degree review successful? Harvard Business Review. https://hbr.org/2020/12/what-makes-a-360-degree-review-successful

Further Reading

Bracken, D. W., Rose, D. S., & Church, A. H. (2016). The evolution and devolution of 360 feedback. *Industrial and Organizational Psychology, 9*(4), 761-794.